

Framework Overview — Developmental SEL-Aligned Model for Ethical AI Literacy

Be Kind to Your Robot Friends

A developmental framework exploring how Social and Emotional Learning competencies can support responsible human engagement with emerging artificial intelligence systems.

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April 2026

Richard Silverman is an independent educational framework developer exploring the intersection of social-emotional development, ethical technology use, and contemplative approaches to learning. His work focuses on practical developmental models that educators can adapt within existing learning environments.

Working model offered for educational dialogue and collaborative refinement.

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Be Kind to Your Robot Friends

Purpose of this document

This overview provides a structural summary of the developmental model described in the full *Be Kind to Your Robot Friends* framework. It is intended to give reviewers a quick understanding of the framework’s educational philosophy, developmental progression, and alignment with Social and Emotional Learning (SEL) priorities.

Core Idea

Be Kind to Your Robot Friends proposes a K–12 and postsecondary framework for social-emotional and ethical AI literacy that prepares students to use AI systems responsibly, thoughtfully, and collaboratively as these technologies become part of everyday learning and work.

The central premise is simple:

AI may generate outputs, but humans remain responsible for how it is used and what results from it.

Rather than focusing primarily on technical skills, the framework emphasizes the human capacities that determine whether AI is used wisely: judgment, communication, responsibility, and ethical awareness.

Educational Philosophy

The framework is built on three guiding ideas:

AI literacy is fundamentally human literacy

Students benefit most from learning how their thinking, communication, and decision-making shape AI outcomes.

Social and emotional competencies transfer into digital environments

Skills such as self-management, responsible decision-making, and relationship awareness become directly relevant when students interact with responsive technologies.

Early habits shape long-term technology behavior

Introducing reflective and responsible use early helps establish healthy patterns before misuse or overreliance develops.

Developmental Progression

The framework proposes a five-stage developmental pathway aligned with student maturity and SEL growth:

Early Elementary (approximately grades K–2)

Students develop awareness that words, tone, and kindness influence outcomes in both human and digital interactions. Activities emphasize communication awareness and respectful engagement.

Upper Elementary (approximately grades 3–5)

Students begin understanding that AI responses are shaped by questions. Activities focus on improving prompts, asking clearer questions, and recognizing that better inputs often produce better results.

Middle School (approximately grades 6–8)

Students develop inquiry habits such as comparing responses, checking information, and recognizing that AI outputs require human verification. Emphasis is placed on curiosity and emerging critical thinking.

High School (approximately grades 9–12)

Students explore bias, ethical dilemmas, limitations of AI systems, and responsible use. Activities encourage evaluation, discernment, and thoughtful participation in AI-supported environments.

Postsecondary

Learners examine governance, professional responsibility, societal impacts, and the role of human judgment in increasingly automated systems. Emphasis shifts toward stewardship and leadership in responsible technology use.

Focus on Judgment Rather Than Technical Complexity

The framework intentionally does not depend on programming knowledge or technical infrastructure. Instead, it develops transferable habits including:

- Critical thinking
- Discernment
- Ethical reasoning
- Communication awareness
- Verification practices
- Responsible participation

These capacities support students regardless of how AI technologies evolve.

Practical Classroom Integration

The model is designed to integrate into existing educational structures such as:

- Social and Emotional Learning programs
- Digital citizenship instruction
- Literacy and research skills
- Civics and ethics discussions
- Technology or media courses

Activities emphasize discussion, reflection, and guided experimentation rather than specialized software or equipment.

Because the framework is modular, educators may adopt small elements without requiring systemic change.

Examples of Learning Activities

Example learning experiences include:

- Comparing multiple AI responses to the same question
- Practicing prompt improvement
- Identifying potential inaccuracies
- Reflecting on communication tone
- Story development with AI collaboration
- Ethical discussion scenarios
- Verification exercises

These activities emphasize thinking processes rather than tool mastery.

SEL Alignment

The framework naturally supports CASEL's five competency areas:

Self-Awareness

Students reflect on how their intentions and communication affect outcomes.

Self-Management

Students practice pausing, revising, and approaching AI interaction thoughtfully.

Social Awareness

Students recognize how communication choices influence interactions and outcomes.

Relationship Skills

Students strengthen clear communication and collaborative interaction habits transferable across contexts.

Responsible Decision-Making

Students learn that humans remain accountable for evaluating and using AI outputs responsibly.

Guiding Principle

The framework is guided by a simple educational principle:

AI should augment human thinking, not replace it.

Education therefore plays a critical role in preparing students not just to use AI tools, but to guide them wisely.

Overall Purpose

This work is intended as a developmental roadmap to help educators prepare students to interact with AI with wisdom, accountability, and humanity.

At its heart, the framework suggests that:

Ethical communication habits developed early may help shape how future generations collaborate with AI in healthy and responsible ways.

Relationship to the Full Framework Document

This overview is intended as a structural summary. The full *Be Kind to Your Robot Friends* framework document provides:

- Detailed developmental competencies
- Classroom activity examples
- Implementation considerations
- Research grounding
- SEL integration details

Closing Note

This work is offered as a contribution to ongoing conversations about how SEL principles may help guide responsible AI literacy development. It is intended as a starting point for exploration, discussion, and collaborative refinement.